

H. Kalpana Rao

Earlier this year, I sent a New Year's card to a student who was visually impaired and was taken aback when he responded saying that he had used an AI tool that provided him with details of the layout, the colours, the pictures within the frame, and even the emotional framework of the image. The confidence with which he immediately pointed out that he was able to grasp the image's nuances through an AI-generated tool made a deep impression on me.

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is today being viewed as an advantage and a disadvantage in relation to academic integrity, learning ability, and evaluation. But the above incident compelled me to rethink the capacities of AI and the range of its possible uses within the field of disability.

Persistent difficulty

For years, instructors have devised innumerable ways to teach, educate, and communicate with students with diverse disabilities. Yet, one of the persistent difficulties has been enabling such students to participate fully in the classroom. For instance, a visually impaired student who had to dictate to a scribe invariably took longer than others to complete a writing task. Added to this was the scribe's own ability to write the dictated material correctly.



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AI for inclusive education

While AI tools can help create an inclusive environment for students with disabilities, educators also should be aware of the problems involved

With AI, such students can dictate and use generative tools to produce responses. Of course, there is potential for misuse but, with appropriate monitoring, this challenge can be addressed.

Similarly, AI can be used to understand maps and charts and assist with reading quickly. Teachers can also create assignments that match the students' intellectual abilities, thereby instilling appropriate challenges. AI can also assist other kinds of disabilities, such as students with cerebral palsy, allowing them to transcribe their

thoughts and write meaningfully.

While teaching postgraduate students, I often faced challenges when working with visually impaired learners. Although I often read passages aloud and encouraged discussions so that all students could follow what was happening, there were moments when I would sometimes write key terms and references on the blackboard, forgetting that visually impaired students could not access what was written. Over the years, I became more aware of their needs and would con-

sciously speak louder so that they could record the audio. I also searched for e-books so that they could access the material independently.

But, in many Indian universities, teachers are not fully aware of how to create equitable and inclusive environments not because they lack the desire but because classrooms are often ill-equipped and have minimal technological access. Additionally, the heavy load of teaching and administrative work makes teaching feel like a burden rather than a pleasure.

It is high time that educators in India become aware of the various tools and strategies emerging through AI to support students. More importantly, curricula and syllabi need to be co-designed with disabled students and instructors so that lived experiences can shape more effective learning. The need of the hour is for university administrators to ensure that faculty are trained to meet the needs of disabled students. Training in the use of and understanding how AI can help innovate and support inclusive teaching practices

is essential. Policymakers should also set guardrails to ensure that technologies remain unbiased and inclusive of diverse perspectives.

Cause of concern

While the use of AI is exciting, it is also a cause of concern. Many AI tools collect user data and store it and this could lead to unwanted data exposure. Moreover, there could be the potential for the data to be collected in methods that are not very transparent. As a result, it could create a risk between technological enhancement and surveillance, especially when data protection protocols are not well-crafted.

Yet another issue that needs to be tackled is that AI systems could be stereotypical, as they are generated using vast data sets and in cultures that may be different. As a result, it may misread the needs of individual students and create problems in assessment and evaluation. A third issue is that students could become too dependent on it and may not understand that it is only a tool to enable them to earn better. Yet, if teachers understand the principles of ethics, integrity, and moral responsibility, AI can become a powerful tool to enhance learning and knowledge among students with disabilities.

The writer is a former professor of English at Pondicherry University and now volunteers as the editor for the literary section of the online journal, *Muse India*. Email: hkalp.eng@pondiuni.ac.in

SCHOLARSHIPS

University of Bath School of Management Scholarships

Offered by the School of Management, University of Bath, the U.K.

Eligibility: Students who have accepted an offer for one of the eligible taught postgraduate Master's courses in 2026-27 and have applied for a scholarship within the deadline.

Rewards: Up to €10,000 fee waiver.

Application: Online

Deadline: April 8

www.b4s.in/edge/UBMS2

Masters' Union Scholarship

Offered by Masters' Union

Eligibility: Students who have passed Class 12 and want to do a full-time UG programme in Business Management; Technology;

Leadership; Design; Sustainability; Finance and Economics; Marketing, or related fields and score in Masters' Union Scholarship Aptitude Test (MUSAT) or approved alternate test.

Rewards: Fee waivers ranging from 10-80%

Application: Online

Deadline: May 13

www.b4s.in/edge/MUSCASPI

ServiceScape Scholarship

Offered by ServiceScape.

Eligibility: Students above 18 years and enrolled or accepted in an accredited college, university, or trade school who submit an essay of 300-600 words on a topic provided by ServiceScape.

Rewards: \$1,000

Application: Online

Deadline: November 30

www.b4s.in/edge/SSSZ2

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

Women in STEM

Progress Software has opened applications for the 2026 Progress Akanksha Scholarship for Women in STEM in India. Two recipients will be chosen based on academic achievement, financial need, interest and experience in Computer Science, Software Engineering, IT and/or Computer

Information Systems and other criteria.

Eligibility: Indian citizens who are women and enrolled in the first year of a Computer Science, Computer Science Information Technology or related courses with an aggregate of 75% or more in Class 12 and a family income not exceeding ₹500,000

Deadline: April 13

For details visit <https://tinyurl.com/sr764hne>



OFF THE EDGE

Nandini Raman

I am doing B.Sc. Biotechnology, but my goal is the Civil Services. I chose this without realising my true interests. I want to study Sociology, English, and Ethics at the PG level. How can I align this with my plans? Ayush

Dear Ayush,

Civil Services does not require a specific undergraduate degree, nor does it require continuity between UG and PG subjects.

Your interests in Sociology, English, and Ethics are highly aligned with UPSC.

Biotechnology will be very useful for General Studies to answer questions in science and technology. So it is also a helpful foundation.

Your Postgraduate choices could be M.A. Sociology (GS-I (Society) and GS-IV (Ethics) and the Essay paper. M.A. English will help in writing and articulation, the Essay paper and the possibility of choosing English as the optional paper.

A PG Diploma in Ethics or Public Policy will help with Ethics Case Studies, governance issues and also help in the interview stage.

I finished Class 10 in 2020 and chose PCMB, aiming to join the Indian Air Force. After Class 12, I missed the NDA's age eligibility. Due to CUET's introduction, I could not secure college admission, leading to a gap year. I enrolled in an online BCA programme. In 2024, I got admission to the B.Sc. Maths (Hons) and, due to financial issues, dropped the BCA. I am also preparing for the CDS and AFCAT. If joining the

Approach is key

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help

defence forces doesn't work, I plan to build a stable career as a data analyst. I have completed a data analytics bootcamp, developed skills such as Excel, SQL, Python, Tableau, Power BI, and cloud tools. What should my next steps be? Nitin

Dear Nitin,

Your path looks a little 'zig-zag' on paper but it showcases your resilience, adaptability, and clarity of intent. You already know CDS/AFCAT are the direct routes but keep a time-bound plan and don't put your life on hold for this.

Create blocks of two to three hours dedicated to preparing for each task. Keep your Plan B also alive and active since you already have great momentum.

Your Maths (Hons.) background, analytics tools stack, and bootcamp exposure give you a good foundation for a data analyst role. Now, you need to focus on projects, internships or live work and visibility.

Work on building four to five solid end-to-end problem-based projects and host them on GitHub, Medium/Notion. Get some analytics experience via internships, contract roles, or projects in NGOs, research organisations or start-ups.

Leverage your Maths (Hons) knowledge and learn statistics for data analysis, hypothesis testing, probability concepts, and basic econometrics.

Work on your resume and profile. Network and connect with analysts on LinkedIn.

I finished B.Com in 2025. I am from a Hindi-medium background and aim to study in a top B-school. I attempted the CAT a year

ago, but did not score well. I am working on improving my quantitative and logical reasoning skills. How do I improve my English? Rajnandan

Dear Rajnandan,

Being from a Hindi-medium background is not a disadvantage. Poor English is a skill gap, not an identity problem. You can fix it!

Work on speaking with clarity, confidence, expressing ideas logically, and comprehending what is being said.

Read comprehension passages and work on CAT-relevant grammar. Your vocabulary doesn't need to be fancy but you should be able to express what you think and feel.

Practise mock interviews in English where you answer structured views, opinions, and check your confidence in delivery.

Read the English newspaper every day out loud, underline the ideas, summarise them in English and get someone to check it.

Practise speaking for around 15 minutes daily and record yourself. Start with simple everyday topics like "Why MBA", "My favourite food" or "My Best Holiday". Focus on your thoughts and expression. Start to think in English and try not to translate from Hindi to English.

Also work on improving writing skills and write short essays on any topic twice a week. Use positive affirmations and be proud of your roots and where you come from.

I am a Class 11 Humanities student preparing for CLAT 2027. I am unsure about the opportunities

and scope in Humanities. What are my options? Satyam

Dear Satyam,

Humanities builds critical thinking, reading and writing ability, and an understanding of society, law, politics, ethics ... all highly valuable skills in law, policy, media, education, research and governance.

Law is one of the strongest professional outcomes for Humanities students. After your law degree, you can get into litigation, corporate law, judiciary, policy and legislative roles, in-house counsel in companies, legal research, and think tanks.

The other options are undergraduate degrees in Political Science, History, Sociology, Psychology, English, Economics (if you have Maths) or Integrated B.A./M.A. or Integrated B.A./B.Ed. courses.

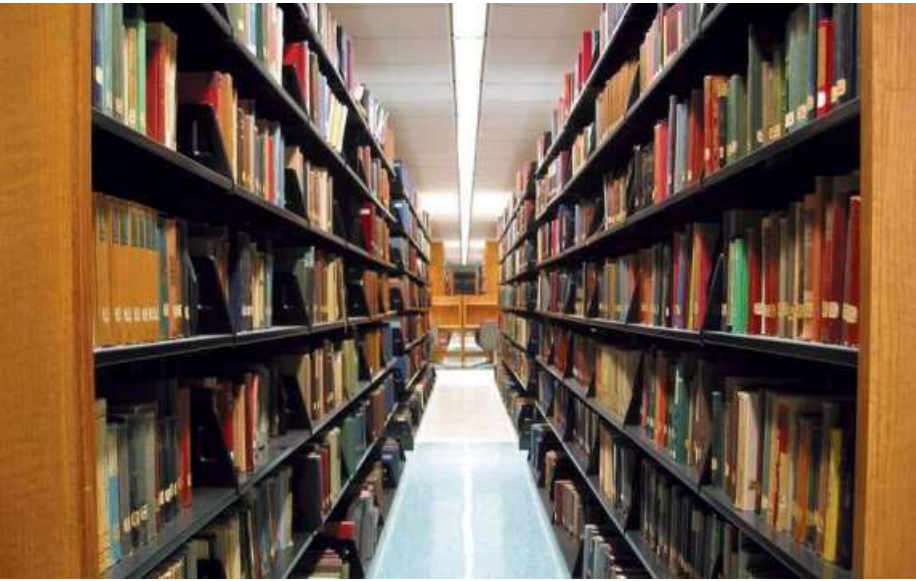
These can lead to multiple postgraduate and career options across public policy and governance, think tanks, research organisations, NGOs, print and digital content writing, corporate communication, civil services and other government exams, academia and so on.

Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge

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The Scopus trap

Why Indian professors are trading creativity for citations

A. Balaji

Imagine a Sahitya Akademi winner being told that his/her life's work is worth "zero" because it isn't in a Scopus database. In the high-stakes world of Indian higher education, a structural paradox is stifling the Humanities. As institutions chase global rankings, scholarly value is increasingly defined not by what is read or taught but by what can be indexed.

Under the current rules of the National Assessment and Accreditation Council (NAAC) and the National Board of Accreditation (NBA), a prize-winning novel or a landmark poetry collection often carries less institutional weight than a poorly written but Scopus-indexed article. We are currently measuring the weight of a soul using a scale designed for coal.

Metrics vs. meaning

The problem lies in the Scopus: Web of Science Trap. Global ranking systems rely heavily on databases that privilege standardised scientific formats. Poetry and creative fiction, published in literary maga-

zines or small presses, remain invisible to these indexing systems. In the cold logic of ranking metrics, if a work is not indexed, it does not exist. This has birthed a "Humanities Gap". While Science and Engineering align seamlessly with citation metrics, creative and practice-based research in the Arts is systematically disadvantaged. We are currently measuring knowledge produced in the library using tools designed for the laboratory.

Standardised research is often a "report" on what already exists. Creative writing is the act of bringing something new into existence. A research article on "Social Isolation in Urban India" provides data, percentages, and trends. However, a play about a lonely elderly man in a high-rise apartment makes the audience feel that isolation. Creative writing preserves the "soul" of a culture – its nuances, slang, and emotional landscape – which data points simply cannot capture. Most research articles are locked behind paywalls and written in jargon that only experts un-

derstand. A poem or a play is democratic; it can be read by anyone. It travels further and stays in the memory longer than a table of citations.

Internationally, the tide is turning. Forward-thinking frameworks now recognise Non-Traditional Research Outputs (NTRs) to avoid the false equivalence that treats all knowledge as a journal article. The U.K.'s REF 2029 evaluates poems as "outputs", even allowing major collections to be "double-weighted" to reflect significant intellectual labour. In Australia, the ERA system tracks poetry under "Code J3", requiring a "Research Statement" to justify its scholarly contribution. In European countries, creative work is treated as a "research artefact", where the work itself is the primary site of knowledge. In the U.S., tenure committees routinely count poems as primary outputs based on publisher reputation and critical reception. All this proves that recognising art doesn't mean lowering the bar; it means redefining rigour for different disciplines.

India doesn't need to

clone the U.K.'s REF or Australia's ERA. It needs to borrow their conceptual clarity. A poem or a translation is not a substitute for research; it is research, conducted through a specific mode of inquiry. By adopting a lean NTR framework, bodies like NAAC and NBA can bridge the gap between creative output and research evaluation without a structural overhaul.

Strategies

A first step is to formalise creative categories and explicitly recognise poetry, translation, and performance as valid research and not dismiss as "extra-curricular". Next comes the Research Context Note. Instead of a technical paper, allow a two-page brief detailing the work's intellectual background, originality, and critical acclaim received. Third, existing criteria needs to be mapped and creative works can be interpreted under current parameters like Criterion 5 (Faculty Contribution) or Program Outcomes regarding societal relevance. Fourth is to apply weighted recognition and acknowledge that a book-length project involves more labour than a short-form article and grant it higher qualitative weight. Finally, mandate that institutional repositories archive creative works digitally alongside their research notes for transparent audit verification.

The goal is simple: start measuring knowledge in all its forms, rather than just its most "index-friendly" expressions. It is time for Indian accreditation to value the meaning behind the metrics.

If the professors aren't rewarded for being creative, they won't teach students to be creative. That's the real loss for India's workforce.

The writer is an Assistant Professor of English, specialising in Communication and Language Studies, at Velammal Engineering College, Chennai.

Manohar Javvaji

Millions of students in Class 10 and Class 12 are asked to choose a stream that will not only shape the next few years of education but also the trajectory of their working life. But this choice is seldom made in isolation.

Parents worry about security, relatives offer comparisons, society amplifies prestige, and the market promotes trends. What is largely missing is the fundamental factor of having reliable insights into the students themselves.

External pressure

outdated approach by introducing evidence-based self-understanding and shifts the question from “What should I become?” to “Who am I and where am I most likely to thrive?” Studies show that 60-70% of students choose their streams based on parental or societal expectations rather than aptitude. While this doesn’t always lead to failure, it frequently leads to dissatisfaction. Around 40% consider changing their stream in the first two years of college, citing poor fit rather than academic difficulty. Many can cope with misaligned courses, but coping is not engagement. Over time, this gap manifests as loss of motivation, anxiety, declining performance, or quiet acceptance of careers that never fit.

There is a persistent belief that ambition and hard

Own your choice

How psychometric evaluation can help students gain clarity over the educational and career paths



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work can compensate for any mismatch. While effort is important, alignment matters more. Research shows that students who select subjects aligned with their aptitude and interests are up to twice as likely to remain engaged throughout their course. Engaged students learn with curiosity, persist longer, recover faster from setbacks, and show stronger intrinsic motivation.

Not a one-time verdict

Psychometric assessments are often misunderstood as rigid tools that box students into predefined outcomes. In reality, their power lies in reflection, not prediction. They evaluate learning styles, cognitive strengths, personality traits, emotional intelligence, and interests, translating intuition into insight. They are not to be used as a one-time verdict.

Their real value emerges when assessments are repeated, interpreted with counselling support, and framed as evolving self-knowledge. Psychometrics illuminates tendencies, preferences, and strengths, allowing students to make informed choices rather than reactive ones and widens opportunity.

While traditional career guidance funnels students toward a narrow set of visible job titles, psychometric insights encourage exploration of career clusters and groups of roles with similar cognitive and personality demands.

Understanding underlying strengths helps students resist peer pressure and short-term trends, reducing early disengagement and repeated course changes. Students who make informed decisions early are less likely to face

mid-career dissatisfaction. Self-awareness becomes a lifelong asset, enabling adaptability across industries rather than dependence on linear paths.

The future of career guidance is not about predicting which jobs will exist tomorrow but about equipping students with the self-awareness to navigate change confidently. Psychometrics shift career decisions from guesswork to evidence-based understanding. For parents, it means moving from control to collaboration. For students, it means replacing pressure with proof. When decisions are grounded in data, anxiety gives way to confidence. Choices feel owned, not imposed. Psychometrics do not promise certainty but offer clarity.

The writer is co-founder of Impacters.

A textbook case

The recent controversies over NCERT textbooks offer a valuable lesson for those involved in preparing textbooks for schools



WIDE ANGLE
Albert P' Rayan

Of late, the National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT) has been in the news for several controversies related to textbook content. The latest concerns its decision to remove a map from the Class 8 Social Science textbook that depicted Bikaner, Bundi, and Jaisalmer as part of the Maratha Empire after the royal family of Jaisalmer objected and claimed this was historical inaccuracy.

Another instance was a two-page section in the Class 8 Social Science textbook discussing corruption at various levels of the judiciary, included in the chapter titled “The Role of the Judiciary in Our Society”. This prompted a strong response leading the Supreme Court to take suo motu cognizance of the matter. NCERT not only withdrew the textbook but also issued an apology. But the controversy did not end. The Chief Justice of India ordered immediate seizure of all copies of the book, the initiation a probe to identify those responsible, and demanded accountability from NCERT.

Questions raised

These controversies raise several important questions such as what content textbooks should contain, what ought to be taught, whether the Court’s intervention is justified, and whether textbook writers and editors have violated established guidelines or, conversely, whether their academic freedom has been compromised.

While it is important to assess whether the Court’s action is justified, it is even more crucial to examine why the NCERT has faced sustained criticism over the past decade. Much of this centres on its revision of school textbooks through the selective removal, reduction, or alteration of content in ways that appear to reflect a par-

ticular political ideology or an attempt to rewrite history. This, in turn, raises a deeper concern: does the institution’s recent functioning demonstrate genuine autonomy or suggest that this so-called “autonomous body” has become vulnerable to the influence of those in power?

We cannot say whether the NCERT has learned, or will learn, a lesson from the recent controversy. However, it offers a valuable lesson for those involved in materials preparation, textbook writing, and editing. In this context, it is necessary to consider what makes a good textbook for school students, the factors to be considered while writing one, and what should be avoided in preparation. It is also essential to reflect on the key questions that school administrators and educators should ask when selecting textbooks for their schools and students.

Requirements

Considering the questions raised about NCERT textbooks, it is essential to provide professional development courses for all textbook writers and editors, and to develop new guidelines grounded in both universally accepted and contextually relevant principles.

In a multilingual, multi-religious, and multicultural country like India, textbook writers and editors are expected to not only possess expertise in their respective fields but also to value inclusiveness. They should be open-minded, principled, and committed to the cause of education. Additionally, they need to be trained to prepare instructional materials in a professional and pedagogically sound manner.

The content should be appropriate for the target group; engaging, relevant, accurate, up-to-date, and inclusive. It must be free from religious, cultural, and gender bias, while remaining culturally and linguistically sensitive. Content, particularly in subjects such as history, should be presented objectively with accurate, reliable, and evidence-based information. Above all, it should align with the pre-

scribed curriculum. Since the purpose of education is to inculcate values and promote logical reasoning and critical thinking, activities should be designed to foster empathy and encourage independent thinking.

Freedom to choose

Schools should have the flexibility to select one that best suits their students from a range of textbooks by different publishers. This choice-based approach offers several clear advantages. Each author tends to emphasise different dimensions of a subject – such as historical context, social relevance, or technical detail – thereby giving students a broader and more balanced understanding rather than a single, limited viewpoint.

Moreover, when a concept is not clearly explained or insufficiently illustrated in one textbook, another may present it in a simpler, more practical, or more relatable manner. Exposure to multiple explanations of the same topic helps reinforce learning and strengthens students’ grasp of fundamental concepts.

From an assessment perspective, choosing a book from a variety of textbooks also exposes students to diverse types of exercises. Some authors, particularly those specialising in competitive examinations, provide higher-order and application-based questions that go beyond standard curriculum materials, thereby better preparing students for advanced assessments.

What matters most is academic freedom for textbook authors and editors who are committed to education, understand the importance of sound guidelines, act in students’ best interests, and stand firm against pressure from powerful forces to compromise their work. After all, their unwavering intellectual commitment and courage should be reflected in their work, inspiring educators and learners. Those in power, including the judiciary, must respect academic freedom.

The writer is an ELT resource person and education columnist. rayanaln@yahoo.co.uk

K. MURALI KUMAR



The next in the monthly series by WWF-India that highlights niche and unconventional green careers through the stories of well-known personalities from the field of environment and conservation

Some of my earliest memories are from my father’s photo studio in New Delhi. I grew up surrounded by cameras, negatives, and photographs waiting to be developed. As a child, I watched images slowly appear on paper and was fascinated by that process. Those early moments were my first introduction to the world of images and storytelling.

Years later, during my graduation at Sri Aurobindo College at Delhi University, I was drawn to the idea of a career that would allow me to travel and explore the country. After reflecting on possible paths, cinematography began to feel like a natural direction. To pursue this interest more seriously, I enrolled in a certificate programme in Film and Video Production.

Finding my way

During my training, documentary filmmaking interested me most. because it allowed you to work with real people and real landscapes. I began travelling to remote parts of the country where communities live

GREEN CAREERS HUB

Through my lens

Documentary cinematographer Karan Thapliyal on filming the frontlines of Nature



in close connection with forests, rivers and wildlife, which gradually influenced the kinds of stories I wanted to tell. Over time, my work began to focus more on subjects such as livelihoods, conservation, climate change, and the relationship between people and Nature.

Working on documentaries also means adapt-

ing to the rhythm of the places you are filming. Life on a documentary shoot rarely follows a fixed routine. Many days begin before sunrise when the morning light is best for filming. Landscapes dance and come alive during those early hours and the colours shift minute by minute. Of course, when wildlife is involved, patience be-

With a human touch

What a career in Social Work entails



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at the intersection of health systems and human experience, supporting patients and families as they navigate illness, disability, trauma and end-of-life care. With increasing attention to mental health and holistic healthcare, the relevance of professionally trained social workers in medical settings has never been greater.

Another important specialisation is Human Resource Management (HRM), rooted in the core

social work principle of focusing on the person within a system. It goes far beyond conventional corporate training. Students study HRM and development, labour laws, industrial relations, workplace wellness, organisational behaviour, and HR analytics, alongside core social work methods. This equips graduates to work in industries and organisations where employee well-being and inclusive workplaces are now seen as strategic

imperatives rather than optional ideals.

The Community Development specialisation speaks directly to contemporary concerns of sustainability, inequality and grassroots transformation. Students are trained in sustainable development, innovative approaches with vulnerable populations, natural resource management, sustainable livelihoods, social entrepreneurship and community organisation. With the expansion of Corporate Social Responsibility initiatives and development projects across sectors, graduates find opportunities as programme officers, project managers, and development professionals in NGOs, foundations, and international agencies.

Beyond these, many universities offer additional specialisations like Correctional Social Work, which engages with criminology, the juvenile justice system, prisons, and the rehabilitation and reintegration of offenders. This area requires both systemic understanding and human sensitivity.

Emphasis on research

A defining strength of Social Work education is its emphasis on research. PG programmes train students in social research

methods, data analysis, and academic writing, culminating in a dissertation. This prepares graduates for practice-based roles and careers in research organisations, academic institutions, policy think-tanks, and doctoral programmes.

Currently, students from any academic background can apply for PG in Social Work. However, this is set to change with the release of a new curriculum framework of the Bachelor of Social Work by the National Commission for Allied and Healthcare Professions. In the future, eligibility for MSW will likely require a Bachelor of Social Work (BSW). This gives students from diverse disciplines a four-year window to do a MSW course since the new BSW programme has just been introduced.

In a world searching for balance between growth and compassion, efficiency and equity, social work offers employment and purpose. For those willing to engage deeply, think critically, and act ethically, it remains one of the most relevant and quietly powerful career choices of our times.

The writer is a faculty member at the Social Work Programme, Department of Social & Health Innovation, Prasanna School of Public Health, MAHE, Manipal.